

Don't use the same measure of 'success' for everyone. For some, success is measured in terms of their financial impact; for others, it is measured in terms of the value of their creation; and for others, it can also be measured by what means and values they adopt to move towards their goals (and how or whether they remain true to them). While it is good to cover 'successful' outcomes, it is also important to cover moderate outcomes or failures because they offer greater lessons and opportunities for us than the successes.

Philosophical and ideological discourse in technology is also important. We should raise and highlight issues that address moral dilemmas that people face. We should not cover technology just from the utilitarian perspective—as a means to an end.

Many times, the content I read in mainstream media reflects a complete lack of awareness about concepts such as free software, creative commons, sharing knowledge, ethical technical practices, respecting users and their rights/freedom, and so on. Such reporting just reflects the opinions and positions of various proprietary

software companies, associations and lobbies.

I feel that if more media persons were aware of the free software movement and could reflect on the technical and ideological positions we take in the community, it would help them assess and report on issues in a more balanced and inclusive manner. Sometimes, the lack of this understanding and awareness reinforces popular misconceptions about the technology.

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Each 'smart device' that we see around us is often easy to build if we choose to do so. And there is still no better way to do that than by using free software and hardware.
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Q Any advice for entrepreneurs who are doing business around FOSS, or would want to?

If you want to eliminate proprietary software and devices that don't respect your freedom and privacy, you have

to also build such software and hardware. It can't be somebody else's problem. The other person's need for freedom, respect and privacy is as great as ours. Proactively building products and solutions that do this by default is a way to “be the change that we want to see.”

We can get rid of the problem of 'black boxes in our lives' by using free software and self-hosting. Businesses are at the solutions end of these problems.

The challenges of building a business remain the same, irrespective of whether the primary focus of your business is free software or not. You still have to build and lead a team, you still need to find customers to sell to, and you still need to reach out so that others can discover your offerings. However, choosing free software can greatly ease these challenges.

A free software business charges people for the value it provides. This value is not derived from restricting access to the software or its source code – by definition, a customer has the freedom to use, study, modify and share the software. Hence, the customer is not paying for access to the software.

There are, however, things that customers will definitely pay for: time-to-productivity (how soon can I start using the solution), support and services (who can I call when I have a problem), migration (can you help me shift my work from X to Y), documentation and training (can you also show me/teach me how to do things), hosting and maintenance (can you help me deploy and manage the software as well), and customisation (can you get this software to do that). These are some of the things a free software business can get creative about. **END** 

As suggested by Abhas, here are some resources that can provide valuable insights into FOSS:

1. 'Hackers: Heroes of the Computer Revolution' by Stephen Levy; https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hackers:_Heroes_of_the_Computer_Revolution
2. Source code, documentation and systems written and designed by D.J. Bernstein; <https://cr.yp.to>
3. 'Coders at Work: Reflections on the Craft of Programming' by Peter Seibel; https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Coders_at_work

Abhas provides some pointers on why freedom matters even for students and what it means to be a hacker at <https://abhas.io/students-hackers/>.

For those who have teaching roles in academic institutions (especially faculty members in engineering colleges), Abhas offers a roadmap on why it is important to choose free software to optimise freedom and learning. The presentation is available at <https://abhas.io/for-teachers/>.

For entrepreneurs who are doing business around FOSS, this resource may help: <https://freesoftware.business/>.

In his presentation at <https://abhas.io/no-black-boxes/>, Abhas explains the problem of 'black boxes in our lives' and how we can get rid of them using free software and self-hosting.

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